

The Place of Nusantara in the Sanskritic Buddhist Cosmopolis

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Abstract

This article synthesizes and links together evidence published thus far in secondary literature, in order to highlight the contribution of Nusantara to the genesis and circulation of various forms of Sanskritic Buddhism across Asia from the fifth to the fourteenth century. It places particular emphasis on its expansion via maritime routes. Archaeological vestiges and textual sources suggest that Nusantara was not a periphery, but played a constitutive, Asia-wide role as both a crossroads and terminus of Buddhist contacts since the early centuries of the Common Era. Sumatra, Java, and the Malay Peninsula hosted major centres of Buddhist worship and higher learning that were fully integrated into the trans-Asian maritime network of trade, diplomacy, and pilgrimage. Frequenting by some of the most eminent Buddhist personalities of their times, who prompted doctrinal and cultic developments in South and East Asia, Nusantara may have exerted an influence on paradigms of Sanskritic Buddhism across Asia, rather than being a passive recipient of ideas and practices.

KEYWORDS: Buddhism, Mahāyāna, Mantranaya, Nusantara, Indonesia, Intra-Asian Interactions, Maritime Silk Routes

INTRODUCTION

THE SPREAD OF SANSKRITIC Buddhism(s) across Asia has mainly been studied from a perspective focusing on transmission through the overland routes popularly known as ‘Silk Roads’, emphasizing Central Asia as an important transit corridor and contact zone between South and East Asia. However, current scholarship capitalizing on recent archaeological and epigraphic discoveries, as well as a more comprehensive and careful reading of textual evidence from various cultural areas and historical periods, has recognized the significant role that the trans-Asian maritime networks or ‘Silk Roads of the Sea’ played in shaping premodern intra-Asian connectivity. This has paved the way for an appreciation of the important contribution of the southern rim of Asia – especially South India, Sri Lanka, and Southeast Asia – to the genesis, transformation, and circulation of various forms of Sanskritic Buddhism.

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This novel appreciation of the maritime networks has rectified misconceptions such as the received idea that the Southern regions of India and maritime Southeast Asia had a marginal role in the Buddhist Cosmopolis, as well as the overemphasis on the dominance of Theravāda/Pāli Buddhism in Sri Lanka and mainland Southeast Asia.² In fact, prior to the thirteenth century, both Southeast Asia, especially the Austronesian-speaking littoral and insular regions of Southeast Asia now called ‘Nusantara’³ (Figure 1), and Sri Lanka hosted important (and even predominant) Sanskritic Buddhist traditions.⁴ They also played a constitutive role in the genesis and transmission of both nascent and consolidated forms of Mahāyāna and Mantranaya/Vajrayāna across Asia from the fifth to the thirteenth century. Southeast Asia and Sri Lanka constituted stopovers and entrepôts for traders and voyagers. However, they were also frequented by monks and laymen alike as termini in their own right. Reasons for such visits included: collecting texts, relics, and icons, visiting pilgrimage sites, acquiring knowledge in institutionalized centres of higher learning or from renowned individual masters, and securing royal patronage.

Nusantara played an important, Asia-wide role as both a crossroads and terminus of Buddhist contacts from the early centuries of the Common Era. In one of his recent epigraphical studies, Arlo Griffiths (2014a: 137) makes a case for “the pan-Asian character of Buddhism and the integral place the Indonesian Archipelago once held in the ancient Buddhist world”. Similarly, Peter Skilling notes that “the peninsular and insular worlds of the ‘Southern Seas’ shared in a wide culture of ritual and ideas that stretched from Central Asia to East Asia” (2015: 56). Skilling re-evaluates the important participation of premodern Siam in a much wider world of Buddhist cultural interchange than is usually assumed at present, questioning “whether ‘India’ should always be the ‘centre’, Siam the periphery – a passive recipient of ‘influence’” (2009: 42). Hiram Woodward (2004: 353) has advanced an argument for “treating Indonesia and India as an integral unit well into the ninth century”, even making “a case for possible influence of Borobudur Buddhism upon subsequent developments in India”.

This survey, synthesizing and linking together evidence published thus far in secondary literature, highlights the important and constitutive role played by

²The emphasis on Southeast Asia in the constitution of Pāli Buddhism is not unjustified; although Pāli originated on the Indian subcontinent in the late first millennium BCE, nearly all of the early epigraphic evidence in this language has been found in mainland Southeast Asia (Lammerts and Griffiths 2015: 996), and a significant proportion of the existing manuscripts in Pāli is preserved in present-day Myanmar, Thailand, and Cambodia.

³While the term ‘Nusantara’ is currently used in Indonesia to indicate the whole Indonesian Archipelago and in Malaysia as a synonym of ‘Malay World’, here I mainly refer to the Malay Peninsula and the Western Indonesian Archipelago (especially Sumatra, Java, and Bali).

⁴Indeed, the overwhelming majority of Buddhist texts from Nusantara, whether preserved in inscriptions or palm-leaf manuscripts, and whether in Sanskrit or in vernacular languages, is affiliated to the Sanskritic canon; little evidence of Pāli Buddhism is known (see Ensink 1978: 179 n. 8; Griffiths 2014c: 249).



Figure 1. Buddhist sites in Nusantara (Map by Andrea Acri).

Nusantara in the genesis and circulation of Sanskritic Buddhism(s) across the geographically wide socio-spatial grouping of Maritime Asia (Acri 2016a, 2018). It presents an historical overview of the networks of sites and agents from a geographically broad perspective, emphasizing the maritime interactions that occurred across geographical and cultural boundaries in the region comprising of a web of coastal and inland polities that were connected to each other through a network of cosmopolitan ports and entrepôts from the Bay of Bengal to the South China Sea, over the course of several centuries. In so doing, it advances an alternative, and complementary, historical narrative that takes the ‘southern pathways’, i.e. the sea-based networks, into consideration, thereby revealing the limits of a historiography that is uniquely premised on land-based, ‘northern pathways’ of the transmission of Buddhism across the Eurasian landmass.

TRANS-ASIAN MARITIME NETWORKS AND THE CONSTITUTION OF SANSKRITIC BUDDHISM(S), FROM THE FIFTH TO THE FOURTEENTH CENTURY

Evidence of the long-distance transfer of Buddhism from its north-eastern Indian cradle to the outlying regions of South India, Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia, and China via the maritime routes goes back to the early centuries of the Common Era. From the fifth century onwards, written and material evidence from the southern rim of Asia becomes more substantial, testifying to an efflorescence of long-distance maritime contacts that was to last for several centuries. As is

shown by textual, epigraphic, and art historical materials – including icons, ritual accoutrements, *dhāraṇīs*, manuscripts, and monuments – Buddhist cults, imaginaries, and ritual technologies flourished across the vast swathe of littoral, island, and hinterland territory of Maritime Asia. Buddhist vestiges have been recovered from the Indian Subcontinent littorals, Sri Lanka, the Maldives, peninsular and coastal mainland Southeast Asia, and what are now called the Indonesian Archipelago and the Philippine Islands. These speak in favour of the existence of pervasive and sustained multi-directional Buddhist exchanges among interconnected nodes linking South Asia in the East to China, Korea, and Japan in the West through maritime routes (Acri 2018; Sen 2014c). A poly-centric, geographically wide, and maritime-based approach is necessary to fully appreciate how religious, mercantile, and diplomatic networks acted as catalysts for the transmission of Buddhism far and wide across Asia over nearly two millennia. Making a case for a multi-centric circulation of Buddhism, rather than a monodirectional transmission from a South Asian ‘homeland’ to Southeast and East Asian ‘peripheries’, recent scholarship has unveiled the multi-directional connections existing between Buddhist centres, tied to each other by overlapping networks of relations that were religious as much as economic, diplomatic, and political in nature (Sen 2003, 2014a, 2014b). Therefore, in order to grasp the multifaceted, trans-regional phenomenon of the patterns of maritime Buddhist transmission across Asia, it is necessary to adopt a network approach, focusing on links between nodes and conduits, the movement of agents, and their role in dynamic processes of exchange.⁵

While it is undeniable that the overland and maritime ‘Silk Roads’⁶ were fundamentally interlinked and complementary, combined archaeological and textual evidence increasingly points to the predominant role of the latter in facilitating the mobility of Buddhist agents, artefacts, texts, and ideas over long distances from the early centuries of the first millennium of the Common Era. By the second century AD, the seasonal Monsoon winds were fully exploited by maritime traders plying the routes connecting the ports in the Mediterranean Sea with those along the coastal and insular areas of South, Southeast, and East Asia. The sea was a connecting factor in Asian history from time immemorial:⁷ cutting across the natural boundaries and barriers of continental topography, sea-based routes formed a network of conduits that led to the formation of a mediaeval global Buddhist Asia. By the middle of the seventh century, factors

⁵See, for example, Neelis 2011 on early Buddhism and trade networks in northwestern India.

⁶While the expression ‘Silk Roads’ (*Die Seidenstrassen*) was coined by the German geographer Ferdinand von Richthofen in 1877, the conceptualization of ‘Silk roads of the sea’ might go back to French scholar Édouard Chavannes (1903: 233). The expression ‘Silk Road(s)/Route(s)’ has been recently critiqued on the ground that silk was by no means the most commonly traded commodity: see Sen 2014c: 39–40.

⁷Recent surveys of the evidence of pre- and proto-historical maritime contacts between South Asia, Southeast Asia, and Southern China are Hoogervorst 2012 and Acri *et al.* 2017.

such as the radical expansion of commercial maritime routes connecting South with East Asia, as well as the gradual decline of Buddhism and Buddhist exchanges in Central Asia following the Muslim conquest of Transoxiana and other socio-political contingencies, contributed significantly to the sea-based exchange, not only of mercantile goods, but also of Buddhist beliefs and ritual practices.

The existence of Buddhist monasteries near major commercial nodes and trading routes from the early centuries of the Common Era up to the thirteenth century may have facilitated the spread of Buddhism, as well as ensured its support by merchant communities. Early and mediaeval sites in the Western Deccan, the Konkan coast, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, and Tamil Nadu were strategically located in the vicinity of ports along the trade routes connecting the mainland to Sri Lanka and further afield to Southeast Asia. This testifies to the increasing popularity of maritime travel in Buddhist communities from the sixth century onwards. The concurrent development in the same locales of ‘Saviour Cults’ – focusing on the bodhisattvas Avalokiteśvara, Tārā (especially in her *aṣṭamahābhaya* aspect), and Mahāpratisarā as protectors of travellers, and of sailors in particular, against the perils encountered along their journeys – may have been due to the increasing number of merchants and monks plying the commercial routes.⁸ While it is undeniable that lay householders active in trade, crafts, and warfare played a role in patronizing and spreading Buddhism through pilgrimage, travel, and migration, the success of Buddhism overseas is to be attributed primarily to royal sponsorship. According to Ronald Davidson (2002: 82–83, 167), an important factor in the rise and quick spread of esoteric fashions of Buddhism across Asia from the seventh century was the loss of mercantile support due to the dominance of Persian/Muslim traders on the Indian Ocean network, and the concomitant escalation in royal patronage. This was made possible through the intimate relationship between ritual specialists and the political elites who, lured by the promise of invincibility, protection for the state, and superhuman powers, often employed tantric monks as royal chaplains – thereby following the pattern that already existed between Brahmanical *purohitas* and the courts that they served. Significantly, many of the powerful dynasties that were instrumental in the sponsorship and spread of Sanskritic Buddhism ruled over domains located along the nodes of commercial and diplomatic maritime networks, such as the Pālas in Northeastern India, the Bhauma-Karas in Odisha, the Early Second Lambakaṇṇas in Sri Lanka, the Śailendras in Sumatra and Java, and the Tangs in China.

Historical evidence going back to at least the third century provides us with a picture of a steady traffic of itinerant monks travelling both eastwards and westwards along the sea paths linking a swathe of territory across the Indian Subcontinent and Japan, in search of texts, teachers, and patrons. It would seem that

⁸See Boppearachchi 2014: 161–187; Ray 2012: 56–60; Guy 2014: 226–264.

most of the monks travelling both ways between India and China preferred the maritime route to the overland one, or at least sought to include a maritime leg in their journey, which usually included stopovers in Sri Lanka and Nusantara. Seventh-century monk Yijing informs us that a significant number of the Chinese and Korean monks who went to India and Southeast Asia during his time travelled by sea on merchant ships (Pachow 1960: 211; Kandahjaya 2004: 58). As recorded by a conservative scholarly estimate, 66 out of the 103 monks (of all ethnicities and geographical provenances) who were involved in the transmission of Buddhism to China used the maritime routes.⁹

While the names and life circumstances of most of those anonymous agents are bound to remain unknown to us, Sino-Japanese biographies allow us to reconstruct the pedigree and social circle of some prominent monks who have gone down in history as vigorous translators, commentators, authors of original texts, initiators of lineages, royal advisers, and thaumaturges.¹⁰ The first monk to travel from India to China via the maritime route was the Sogdian Kang Senghui, who arrived in Nanjing in AD 247. Many more monks are recorded to have reached China from South and Central Asia via Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia from the fourth to the sixth century. From the seventh century, a remarkably mobile and cosmopolitan network of monks is associated with the first wave of Mantranaya. This network includes *Vajrabuddhi (Jingangzhi 金剛智; 671–741) and his ordained pupil Amoghavajra (Bukong 不空; 704–774). We also know about an eighth-century Javanese monk, Bianhong, who went to China to study under Huiguo and composed an esoteric Buddhist initiation manual focusing on state protection (Sinclair 2016a). The networks of seventh- to ninth-century itinerant monks offer a telling picture of the extraordinary period of intra-Asian maritime connectivity that became the hallmark of the rise and spread of esoteric Buddhist traditions over the course of just two or three generations.

As a result of socio-political contingencies,¹¹ the Buddhist traffic between India and China decreased from the ninth century, although smaller regional interlocking networks remained active, and the sea-based transmission of Buddhism between South and Southeast Asia was sustained through the following centuries at the hands of monks and other (possibly non-monastic) agents who are bound to remain anonymous due to the paucity of Chinese records of that period. Notable exceptions are the famous master Atīśa (*Adhīśa/Atīśa?, aka Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna, AD 980–1054), who travelled from northeastern India to Sumatra (*suvarṇadvīpa*) and stayed there for twelve years to study with

⁹Kandahjaya 2004: 78. The number 103 was estimated by P.C. Bagchi (1981: 255–277).

¹⁰For a survey of the most important monks, see Pachow 1960; Sen 2014c; Acri 2016a, 2018.

¹¹Such as the decline and ‘provincialisation’ of Buddhism in China from the middle of the ninth up to the end of the tenth century, the reduced scale of Buddhist building activities in Southeast Asia (with the exception of the Cam domains), the persecution of Buddhists in Tibet, and the emphasis on Śaiva patronage in Java from the mid-ninth century.

*Sauvarṇadvīpī-Dharmakīrti, one of the five most prominent Buddhist intellectuals of his time; the monk-translator Shihu (施護, *Dānapāla, d. 1018), apparently a native of Swāt (now in Western Pakistan), who knew the languages of Śrīvijaya, and must therefore have resided there for some time; and, almost five centuries later, the sixteenth-century Indian Buddhist Siddha Buddhaguptanātha, who is recorded by his student the Tibetan chronicler Tāranātha to have travelled extensively by sea from the Konkan coast to Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia (Java and Sumatra?), and back to visit Buddhist vestiges and communities (Tucci 1931; Templeman 2009).

Despite the lack of biographic records, the continuation or (re)establishment of long-distance contacts across the Indian ocean from the eleventh to the thirteenth century is suggested by certain notable facts. These include the royal-sponsored endowments sent by sea from Myanmar to Bodh Gaya (Singh 2014) and the (re)appearance of Nālandā-style imagery of Buddhist divinities in Angkor, Pagan, the Malay Peninsula, and East Java (Skilling 2007). Another example of this is the election (arguably through initiation) of transgressive and martial forms of ‘Phase Three’ tantric Buddhism as a personal and official cult by important royal figures such as Jayavarman VII in Cambodia (r. c.1181–1220), Kṛtanagara in East Java (r. 1268–1292), Kublai Khan in China (r. 1260–1294), and Ādityavarman in Java and Sumatra (r. ?–1375). The rise of these new networks of tantric Buddhism may have been triggered by unfavourable international political developments, most notably the decline of Buddhism in northern India at the end of the twelfth and beginning of the thirteenth century. When Nālandā, Vikramaśīla, and Uddanāpura had been razed, scholars and artisans fled to Nepal and Tibet (von Schroeder 1981), and possibly further afield to Southeast Asia.¹² According to Tāranātha, most of the Buddhist scholars of *madhyadeśa* fled to mainland Southeast Asia (i.e. the kingdoms of Pegu, Campā, Kamboja, and so on) after Magadha was invaded by the Turks (Chattopadhyaya 1990 [1970]: 330).

SANSKRITIC BUDDHISM IN NUSANTARA—THE CONTRIBUTION OF NUSANTARA TO SANSKRITIC BUDDHISM

Nusantara was a strategic geographical area in the maritime Silk Roads system that has yielded significant vestiges of its glorious Hindu and Buddhist past, yet is still underrepresented in contemporary scholarship. Far from being a cultural backwater that passively received and ‘localised’ Indic influences, it had an integral place in the Buddhist Cosmopolis as both a crossroads and terminus of contacts from the early centuries of the Common Era. The contribution of Nusantara to the Indian Ocean trade network has been recognized through its

¹²See below on the thirteenth-century inscription by Gautamaśrī in Karimun Besar.

provision of superior shipping technology, nautical terminology, and ship crews. However, the creative and constitutive force of Southeast Asian agents and socio-cultural milieux in the transfer, transformation, and translocation of people, texts, notions, and artefacts in the Buddhist world remains to be fully appreciated.¹³ Witness the fact that a number of monks who travelled the sea routes and visited Southeast Asia – such as, for example, *Guṇavarman, *Paramārtha, Yijing, *Vajrabodhi/*Vajrabuddhi, Amoghavajra, and Atiśa – not only contributed to shaping the Buddhist paradigm in that region, but also stirred up new developments in China, Tibet, and the Indian Subcontinent itself (Kandahjaya 2004: 79).

Sparse finds of Buddha images are documented across a vast area from Sumatra and Java to Kalimantan and Sulawesi; although their dating is uncertain, with estimates spanning from the second to the ninth century, they highlight the maritime mobility of Buddhism within the Archipelago. Vestiges of Buddhism, such as *stūpikās*, are also documented on the island of Bali, where communities of specialists in tantric Buddhist rituals have survived down to the present day. It is, however, in Sumatra and Java that the most Buddhist vestiges are concentrated. These two islands were strongholds of Mahāyāna Buddhist tantra from the seventh to the fifteenth century. Significant Buddhist vestiges include: the Batang Hari river sites in Muaro Jambi and Padang Lawas in Sumatra, the central Javanese temple complexes of Borobudur, the Kedu plain, and Ratu Boko; the royal temples of the Siñhasāri and Majapahit kingdoms in east Java; and a number of textual documents preserved in inscriptions and manuscripts.

JAVA

Although Śaivism had been the dominant religion in Java for over a millennium in pre-Islamic times, Buddhism has also had a significant place in the religious, socio-political, and artistic life of the island. Chinese monk Faxian (337, 342–c.422) writes in his account that Buddhism in Java was not worth speaking of and that Brahmanism was very strong. However, just a few years after this, the Kashmirian monk *Guṇavarman, immediately before reaching China, succeeded in converting the royal family and their Javanese subjects to Buddhism. This information could be matched with the extensive, and nearly contemporary, archaeological remains of Batujaya in northwestern Java (Manguin and Indrajaya 2011), and with seventh–early ninth century epigraphic evidence featuring Buddhist formulas traceable to a fifth-century Sarvāstivāda milieu (de Casparis

¹³Cf. Griffiths (2014a: 138): “The existence of these mantra and *dhāraṇī* inscriptions in Indonesia has not as yet played any role whatsoever in the study of Indian and pan-Asian Buddhism... This seems to be a loss as much for the study of the history of pan-Asian Buddhism, as it is for the study of Indonesian cultural history”. Few, if any, references to material from Nusantara are found in recent seminal monographs on Esoteric Buddhism, such as Davidson’s (2002).

1956: 75). Another report by Yijing indicates that, by the middle of the seventh century, the Sarvāstivāda school was prevalent in Southeast Asia,¹⁴ and that the Chinese monk Huining visited ‘Kaliṅga’ (*holing*) in central Java from AD 665 for three years, to study and translate Āgama literature with a local (波凌人) *śramaṇa* called Jñānabhadra. Huining’s pupil, Yunqi, after going back to China to present a Chinese translation of the *Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra*, returned to Southeast Asia, spending more than ten years in Java and living in Śrīvijaya up to the time of Yijing.¹⁵

Art historical and textual remains point to the existence of close Buddhist links between western India, the Malay Peninsula, and Java in the eighth century. The seemingly ‘archaic’ character of eighth–ninth century Mantranaya Buddhism in Java and Sumatra, when the two islands were under Śailendra rule, suggests that the early esoteric developments that were emerging from the western Deccan promptly reached Nusantara via the maritime routes; these became the basis of, and were preserved in, later religious configurations. For instance, the ‘courtly’ eighth-century Eight Bodhisattvas known from some of the Ellorā caves, Ratnagiri, and the Malay Peninsula, where they are part of a *maṇḍala* arranged around a Śākyamuni, are depicted on the exterior walls of Candi Mendut and in the interior of Candi Plaosan (Bautze-Picron 1997). Significantly, this maṇḍalic formation is described in the ‘proto-tantric’ *Aṣṭamaṇḍala-kasūtra*, translated into Chinese by Amoghavajra (*T* 1167) and, a century earlier, by *Puṇyodaya (Nati 那提, *T* 486). Amoghavajra travelled to China via Java, and *Puṇyodaya was active in Cambodia (Woodward 2004: 336; Lin 1935: 83–100). Indeed, similarities between the iconography of the Eight Bodhisattvas in Java, Shingon Buddhism, and eighth-century Chinese translations have been discerned by Bautze-Picron (1997: 28). A possible iconographical influence stemming from the later ‘esoteric’ phase of Ellora and other western Indian caves is detectable on the sculpted triptych of Mendut (Revire 2018) and, perhaps, Candi Bogang in central Java.¹⁶ This could represent the triad of Avalokiteśvara-Padmapāṇi, Śākyamuni, and Vajrapāṇi. These deities are seen as the three heads of bodhisattva families in texts belonging to the Kriyātantra genre, such as the *Susiddhikarasūtra* and the *Mañjuśrīyamūlakalpa*. This confirms the archaic, pre-systematized character of Mantranaya or the Mahāyāna Buddhist tantra in the Śailendra domains in the eighth and ninth centuries.¹⁷ Another echo of the *Susiddhikara* and other early tantric texts is found in a pan-Asian

¹⁴See Takakusu 1896: 10: “In the islands of the Southern Sea – consisting of more than ten countries – the Mālasarvāstivādanikaya has been almost universally adopted”.

¹⁵See Kandahjaya (2016: 85; T2066), who points out that Jñānabhadra is recorded in the T377 as having translated the *Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra* (in a personal communication, Iain Sinclair suggested that this is actually the Mahāyāna version of the text).

¹⁶Degroot (2009: 344) reports that excavations “have brought to the light one Buddha and two bodhisattva (Vajrapāṇi and, supposedly, Avalokiteśvara)”.

¹⁷See below on the presence of these deities in the Chaia/Vieng Sa inscription from the Malay Peninsula.

pericope including the sequence *namaś caṇḍavajrapāṇa-ye/-yiṣya mahāyakṣa-senāpat-aye/-iṣya*, found in incantations recovered from epigraphic documents from Java and Bali, such as the *Mahāraudra-nāma-hṛdaya* (Griffiths 2014a: 183–184, 2014b). Two *maṇḍala*-stakes (*kīla*) from central Java, palaeographically dateable to the ninth or tenth century, contain versions of mantras also found in the *Guhyasamāja* and the ninth-century ritual manual *Sarvavajrodaya* by Ānandagarbha, and version B of the *Sarvadurgatipariśodhana* (2014a: 170–171). Although the exact relationship between *dhāraṇī*s preserved in written texts (manuscripts) and inscriptions is often difficult to disentangle, especially concerning the issue of directionality, the existence of close parallels in the *Sarvavajrodaya* suggests that the latter text might have been the source of the central Javanese material, in which case it must have reached the island soon after its composition. The availability of Mantranaya material at an early period in Java, including a gold foil from Candi Plaosan Lor containing the exact same version of a *dhāraṇī* as can be found in the Sanskrit texts brought to Japan by Kūkai in the early eighth century (Griffiths 2014a: 165), as well as a representation of the *Gaṇḍavyūha* – a text that Osto (2009) regards as ‘proto-tantric’¹⁸ – on the Borobudur, suggests not only that a ‘commonality of religious culture’, especially with respect to *dhāraṇī*-focused Buddhism, existed across Nusantara and other locales of the Buddhist Cosmopolis, but also that Nusantara may have played a role in the circulation and development of ideas and practices.

The major architectural undertakings of the Śailendra dynasty in the eighth and ninth centuries included the majestic and exquisitely crafted Buddhist monuments of Borobudur, Candi Mendut, Candi Sewu, Candi Kalasan, and Candi Plaosan (Plate 1). Borobudur remains the largest Buddhist monument ever built and stands unrivalled in its architectural complexity, symbolical depth, and artistic quality.¹⁹ Candi Kalasan has yielded one of the biggest bronze bells ever recovered from a Buddhist monument, and may have hosted a colossal statue of Tārā that is, unfortunately, no longer extant. These temples, constituting artistic and architectural masterpieces, must have ranked among the great sacred centres of the Buddhist Cosmopolis, and attracted a steady traffic of monks and pilgrims to the island. For instance, a ninth-century Siddhamāṭṛkā inscription unearthed at Plaosan in the Prambanan area describes the worship at a Buddha-temple (*jinamandira*) by pilgrims continuously arriving from Gurjaradeśa in north India (de Casparis 1956: 188–189, 202). An account by Yuanzhao

¹⁸This text, and in particular the *bhadracarī*, has been linked to the monk *Prajña (Boruo 般若, alt. Bolaru 般刺若; c. 744–810, who translated it for the third time; in his translation, the latter text was incorporated in the former as its last chapter: see *T* 293). Since *Prajña reached China from South-east Asia in AD 780, he might have been the source for the depiction the *Gaṇḍavyūha-Bhadracarī* at Borobudur (Kandahjaya 2009: 52). It is also notable that the above-mentioned pericope is prefixed to the mantra of Amṛtakuṇḍalin preserved in *Prajña’s handwriting and transmitted to Japan (Giebel 2012: 190–192; cf. Acri 2016b: 337).

¹⁹On its possible northeastern Indian architectural forebears, see Chemburkar 2016.



Plate 1. Candi Paolosan, central Java. (Photo Andrea Acri, 2016).

compiled into the *Zhenyuan xinding shijiao mulu*, as well as a report by the Japanese master Kūkai, records that *Vajrabuddhi first met Amoghavajra in Java (Chou 1945: 321; Sundberg and Giebel 2011: 152). An early eleventh-century illustrated manuscript of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā-Prajñāpāramitā* (CUL Add. 1643) dedicates one of its first vignettes to an image of the Buddha Dīpaṅkara in Java (f. 2r),²⁰ and Java figures in the early ‘tantric geography’ exposed by the *Mañjuśrīyamūlakalpa* (51.636–640).

Links between masters from the Pāla-Sena domains and Śailendra-sponsored Buddhism may be inferred from the Kelurak Sanskrit/Siddhamātrkā inscription of AD 782, recording Kumāraghoṣa, the royal preceptor from Gauḍīdvīpa who installed an image of Mañjughoṣa (Mañjuśrī) at *vajrāsana mañjuśrīgrha* (Candi Sewu in central Java?) at the request of Śailendra King Śrī Saṅgrāmadhanāñjaya (Sarkar 1971, I: 37, 45). The importance of Mañjuśrī in Java, and especially its connection to political power, finds a parallel in the cult of the same deity in esoteric Buddhist circles at the Tang court during roughly the same period.²¹ The

²⁰One notes the scantiness of textual and iconographical evidence relating to this Buddha in both pre-seventeenth-century Nepal and Java – although, according to Sinclair (p.c.), there is still the possibility that some Nusantara images could have been misidentified as ‘standing Buddhas’ or ‘Śākyamunis’. This fact makes me wonder whether there is a connection between Dīpaṅkara and Atiśa Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna, who travelled to insular Southeast Asia (see below). Indeed, Sinclair (2016b: 165) has noted that the identification of an image of the Buddha Dīpaṅkara at Tham Bahī with the merchant *Siṅhalasārthavāha of *Divyāvadāna* 36 etc. may be a vestigial memory of Atiśa’s maritime journeys.

²¹See Sundberg and Giebel 2011: 130, who trace the centrality of this cult in the Kelurak inscription to Amoghavajra himself. On Mañjuśrī as a political symbol in Central Java, see Miksic 2006.

rājaguru Kumāraghoṣa of the Kelurak inscription is probably to be identified with the anonymous *śailendrarājaguru* praised in the Siddhamāṭṛkā Sanskrit inscription of Kalasan of AD 778.²² This document opens with a salutation to Āryā-Tārā, and mentions the construction of a temple for Tārā (*tārābhavana*), which Jordaán (1998) identifies with what is now called Candi Kalasan. In a fragmentary line of the Siddhamāṭṛkā Sanskrit inscription of Plaosan, the wife of an unidentified royal figure is said to “shine forth like Tārā” (*tāreva virājati*) (Long 2014: 244); the same simile (*tāreva*) occurs in the Nālandā copper plate of Devapāla, linking that goddess to the queen-mother of Bālaputra – a Śailendra royal figure known in mid-ninth-century Sumatra and Java (Sastri 1923–24: 326). On the basis of this epigraphic evidence and art historical material, Jordaán (1997: 287–288) has hypothesized that the Tārā cult in Java and Sumatra was connected to the contemporary Pāla royal cult of (Śyāmā-)Tārā. Be this as it may, both areas are likely to have acted as an important place in the development of the cult of Tārā, which had an inherent maritime aspect – this goddess being a tutelary deity of travellers, and seafarers in particular (Bopearachchi 2014; Ray 2012: 56–60).

A steady Buddhist traffic must have linked Java and Sri Lanka, as evidenced by biographies of monks, as well as epigraphic and art historical evidence from both islands. An eighth-century foundation inscription, again in the Sanskrit language and Siddhamāṭṛkā script, records that a branch of the Sri Lankan Abhayagirivihāra was established by the Śailendras on the Ratu Boko promontory in central Java (Plate 2). The Ratu Boko structures were apparently intended for the use of esoteric-minded Sinhalese Buddhist ‘rag-wearing monks’ (*pāṃśukūlika*),²³ who were active in the eclectic monastic institution at Anurādhapura where a variety of Buddhist texts were studied. Significantly, the Abhayagirivihāra-related structures of Ratu Boko share common architectural motifs, such as the peculiar double meditation platforms, with their Sinhalese prototypes (Sundberg 2016). Indeed, the area in the Kedu plain where Candi Sewu and the Prambanan temple complex were built appears to have been termed Laṅkapura (‘The Laṅkan City’) by then, as if to recreate a local ‘replica’ of Buddhist Sri Lanka (Griffiths 2011a),²⁴ and multiple Abhayagiris

²²Three other royal *ācāryas* of Buddhist affiliation whose names end in *-ghoṣa*, namely Buddhagoṣa, his guru Jinaghoṣa, and the latter’s guru Ratnaghoṣa, are known to us from the nearly contemporary seventh–eighth century inscription of Sirpur in Madhya Pradesh in connection with the upkeep of a *caitya* (Jain 1971).

²³The occurrence of the term *saṃgūdārtha*, ‘esoteric concerns/secret meanings’ (?), in both the Ratu Boko inscription and the Kelurak inscription, is worthy of mention. This could point to an esoteric Buddhist context. Sundberg (2014: 96) aptly regards the Abhayagiri inscription as “the textual equivalent of the Barabudur *stūpa*” in that it is “superficially an expression of conventional Mahāyāna thought but endowed with a deep esoteric undercurrent”.

²⁴The Classical Malay text *Tambo Minangkabau* speaks of a Laṅkapuri island located in the area of “mountain Si Guntang-guntang Mahangiru” (Bukit Siguntang near Palembang?) in the Sea of Ceylon and, later, “between Jambi and Palembang” (Braginsky 2015: 93–94, fn. 34). This makes



Plate 2. The Ratu Boko monumental gate, Central Java. (Photo Andrea Acri, 2016).

could have existed elsewhere in Southeast Asia: namely in southern Cambodia, southern Vietnam, and peninsular Thailand (Griffiths 2013: 75).

Evidence for the pan-Asian cult of Mahāpratisarā, a female deity related to Tārā, has been recovered from Java (Mevisen 1999: 102–103; Crujsen, Griffiths, and Klokke 2012). The popularity of this deity in both Central Java and the centre of the Tang empire in China, namely Dunhuang and Changan, from the eighth to the tenth century, seems to be linked by the activities of Amoghavajra (Mevisen 1999: 117), who not only recited the *Mahāpratisarādhāraṇī* in order to avert shipwreck while travelling to China by sea (Chou 1945: 275, n. 19; Sundberg and Giebel 2011: 139), but actually translated it and submitted a copy of it to Emperor Suzong (*T* 2120.829b2–21) in AD 758.²⁵ A gold foil recovered from the approximately tenth-century Cirebon shipwreck off the Java northern coast, containing a *dhāraṇī* addressed to a goddess personifying the incantation, and paralleling material found in the *Ekādaśamukhadhāraṇī* and *Sādhanamālā* confirms that objects like this were actually worn by passengers and/or crews as amulets intended to protect against the dangers of voyages at sea (Griffiths 2014a: 157–159).

me wonder whether these Laṅka-related toponyms were associated with the Śailendra-Śrīvijaya rulers (compare the kingdom of ‘Laṅkasukha’ in the Malay Peninsula).

²⁵Compare *T*2057.294c23–24, which states that Huiguo sought instruction from Amoghavajra in the mantra of Pratisāra between AD 763 and 765 (Sinclair 2016a, p. 38, fn. 52). We also know about a second translation completed by *Maṇicintana (Baosiwei 寶思惟, d. 721, who is said to have shipwrecked somewhere in the Southern Seas) in AD 693.

Woodward has apprehended the influence of Borobudur on Buddhism in the subcontinent: according to him, this monument could represent an early phase of the system of subtle bodily centres called *cakras* or *sthānas/ādhāras* (2009: 48). Furthermore, the same scholar (1990: 16–17) has advanced the hypothesis that a tenth-century inscription quoting verse 46 of the *Bhadracarī-praṇidhāna* (Schopen 1989) – the text that came to be transmitted as the final chapter of the *Gaṇḍavyūha* depicted in the uppermost series of reliefs on Borobudur – on a memorial *stūpa* found at the Nālandā monastery, which was established in the ninth century by Bālaputradeva for the use of pilgrims from Śrīvijaya, might represent a new stimulus introduced by the Sumatran monarch, or in any event the existence of “longstanding similarities in religious practice” in the two areas (2004: 353). This verse is notable in that it is the only passage from a Mahāyāna text so far recorded in an Indian inscription. It also survives in another inscription that forms part of the Sambas Buddhist hoard found in Western Kalimantan, which contains more verses traceable to Sanskrit texts, namely the *Mahāpratisarāmahāvīdyārājñī* and the *Vajracchedikā Prajñāpāramitā* (Griffiths 2014a: 146–147).

Vestiges of Vajrayāna Buddhism in ninth- and tenth-century Java may be found in the groups of bronzes from Surocolo and Nganjuk, which have been tentatively identified as representing tridimensional esoteric *maṇḍalas* dominated by Vajrasattva, one of the central deities of ‘Phase Two’ and ‘Phase Three’ Esoteric Buddhism (Tanaka 2010: 339). Since the portrayal of this pantheon in paintings or statuary is relatively scarce in the Buddhist world, the Surocolo hoard is especially significant (Szántó and Griffiths 2015: 372). Another hoard, found at Ponorogo, has been associated to goddesses of the Vajrasattvakulamaṇḍala and the *Śrīparamādya* seventeen-deity *maṇḍala* in its connection with the *Sarvabuddhasamāyoga* on the basis of commentaries in Tibetan translation (Matsunaga 2017). A small statuette has been recovered from the cargo of the *Intan* shipwreck salvaged from the waters of Java Sea, which may have belonged to one such tridimensional *maṇḍala* (Liebner 2014: 191–194). These findings testify to the keen interest in initiatory *maṇḍalas* in Java: significantly, the only text attributed to the Javanese monk Bianhong is the ‘Ritual Manual for Initiation into the Great Maṇḍala of the Uṣṇīṣa-Cakravartin’ (*T* 959), and most of the Sanskrit verses cited in the Old Javanese *San Hyañ Kamahāyānan Mantranaya* – a text that identifies its main Buddha with Vajrasattva, the transcendent essence of all Tathāgatas – are traceable to esoteric Buddhist initiatory manuals related to the *Guhyaśamāja* (Kandahjaya 2016). While the date of this text is not certain, a related Śaivized version has a colophon mentioning the name of King Mpu Siṇḍok of the Īśāna dynasty (r. 929–947), and its early core might date back to the eighth or ninth century.

Material stemming from the Trailokyavijaya cycle in the *Sarvatathāgatataṭṭvasaṅgraha*, and also associated with more wrathful Krodha-vighnāntaka deities, is known from Java. Trailokyavijaya/(Caṇḍa)Vajrapāṇi is invoked in

incantations that can be found in epigraphic documents from Java and Bali (Griffiths 2014a: 183–184, 2014b), and at least four images of Trailokyavijaya have been recovered from central Java (probably from the tenth century). Standing in *pratyāḥḍha* posture trampling over Śiva and Umā, these images closely follow Eastern Indian (Pāla) iconographical prototypes. However, the *Mahāraudra-nāma-hṛdaya* that was recovered near Borobudur attests to a major iconographical discrepancy with the known sculptural corpus all over the Buddhist world, namely the placement of the right foot on Śiva and the left foot on Pārvatī's chest, instead of the opposite. To Griffiths (2014b: 32), this suggests a genuine, as yet unattested iconographic variant, rather than a textual error. The 'anti-Śaiva' overtones of this incantation are also found in a short mantra engraved on a gold foil from Ratu Boko in central Java as well as on similar artefacts (Acri 2016b; Griffiths 2014a: 177–180), which are related to the *krodha-vighnāntaka* deity Ṭakkirāja and the *Sarvatathāgatattvasaṅgraha* cycle.²⁶

An emphasis on 'Phase Three' Vajrayāna is detectable in the statuary and epigraphic remains associated with King Kṛtanagara of Siṃhasāri, who was apparently initiated into transgressive, non-dual Buddhist and Śaiva tantric traditions and founded a royal cult identifying the monarch with 'Śiva-Buddha'. The later chronicle *Deśavarṇana* (43.2–5) indicates his commitment to Buddhism, records his initiation name Jñānabajreśvara,²⁷ and associates him with the teachings of the unidentified *Subhūtitantra*,²⁸ as well as the *gaṇacakra* rituals that are known to us via the *Guhyasamāja*. Indeed, Kṛtanagara had a Sanskrit-inscribed, colossal statue portraying him as Mahākṣobhya – the principal deity of the *Guhyasamāja* – installed at the cremation ground of Wurare in AD 1289. Another 5.5 metre-high colossal statue of Akṣobhya going back to the same period lies unfinished at the Reco Lanang site in the vicinity of Trawas in the Mojokerto District of east Java (Plate 3).

A northeastern Indian and/or Nepalese (Newar) influence on the east Javanese Buddhist art and inscriptions of the Siṃhasāri period has been noted, for instance in the statuary and decorative features (O'Brien 1993: 252–255; Lunsingh Scheurleer 2008: 296–298). Schoterman (1994: 168) noted that the five main statues of Bodhisattvas at Candi Jago were executed according to the teachings of the Sanskrit *Amoghapāśasādhana*, which was written by Śā-kya-śrī-bha-dra in northern India around the year 1200 and may have reached Java shortly thereafter. However, Sinclair (2016b: 150) has convincingly argued that the Malay and Javanese forms of eight-armed Amoghapāśa Lokeśvara may predate the textual legacy from the Subcontinent, and may have therefore inspired the Indian and Nepalese specimens – perhaps via a statue installed at Bodh Gaya by an

²⁶Ṭakkirāja is a protector of the gate of the *maṇḍalas* of Uṣṇīṣavijaya, Mañjuvājra (*Guhyasamāja*), and Vajrasattva (*Samputa*).

²⁷Or Jñānaśivabajra in the Wurare inscription.

²⁸A *Saṃ Hyaṇ Tantra Bajradhātu Subhūti* is mentioned in version C of the *Saṃ Hyaṇ Kamahāyānikan* (Kandahjaya 2016).



Plate 3. The Reco Lanang unfinished Akṣobhya statue, east Java. (Photo Andrea Acri, 2016).

Indonesian donor.²⁹ The Nāgarī-inscribed Buddhist statues from Candi Jago, and the occurrence of the words *bharāla* ('god') and *bharālī* ('goddess') in a number of inscriptions associated with Kṛtanagara, support a possible northeastern Indian, and especially Newar, link.³⁰ Interestingly, Nepalese artisans became popular at the courts of both Khubilai Khan in China and his sworn adversary Kṛtanagara in east Java.³¹ The existence of links between Sumatra (and Java?) and northeastern India in the thirteenth century may be evinced by the Pasir Panjang rock inscription in Sanskrit and Rañjanā script at Karimun Besar in the Riau Archipelago, recording a *mahāyānika-gauḍa-paṇḍita-śrīgautamaśrī*: that is, a Mahāyāna scholar from Bengal named Gautamaśrī. This personality, whose identity and presence in Nusantara have been recently discussed by Iain Sinclair (2018), was active in Nepal (specifically at Guitaḥ in Lalitpur) and Tibet before the middle of the thirteenth century, at a time when northeastern

²⁹It is perhaps not coincidental that °Mañicintana, an early Buddhist monk who travelled between India and China through Nusantara, is credited with the translation of a text associated with A-mo-gha-pā-śa Lokeśvara, i.e. the *Scripture of the Amoghapāśadhāraṇī, Sovereign Lord of Spells* (*Bukongjuansuo tuoluoni zizaiwang zhou jing* 不空罽索陀羅 尼自在王咒經, T1097).

³⁰A discussion of the word forms *bharāla* and *bharālī* and their probable cognates *bahāla*, *bahāra*, and *bharāḍa* (<*bhaṭṭāra*[ka]) in Newar sources may be found in Sinclair 2012, 2016b; cf. Griffiths 2014c: 242–243.

³¹We indeed know of a failed attempt by Khubilai Khan to invade east Java: see Bade 2013.

India had just been raided by the Turks and Buddhism was on the decline. The fact that this inscription was written in Sanskrit in a non-local cosmopolitan script, and that it displays a short, graffiti-like (yet well-executed) character, lends credit to the hypothesis that it could have been engraved by Gautamaśrī himself *en route* to mainland Sumatra and/or Java (according to Sinclair, not long after the turn of the first half of the thirteenth century).

In the Majapahit period, Buddhism was a constitutive (albeit seemingly subordinate) member of the religious coalition formed by Śaivism (*śaivapakṣa*), Buddhism (*sogatapakṣa*), and the Ṛṣis. While the term ‘syncretism’ is not appropriate to describe this situation of religious pluralism and inclusivism, it must be noted that the truly hybrid cult of Śiva-Buddha introduced by Kṛtanagara appears to have become popular in this period, as it is frequently encountered in the religious literature as well as in the *belles lettres* (Acri 2015). A fourteenth-century Old Javanese literary source, the *kakavin Sutasoma* by Mpu Tantular, attests to Esoteric Buddhist cults and a form of Mahāyānic tantra that, despite prescribing the worship of Śiva-Buddha (i.e. Mahāvairocana) and preaching a form of identity between the two supreme deities, keeps the Buddhist and Śaiva ways neatly separate. A similar situation is reflected in the fourteenth-fifteenth-century *kakavin Kuñjarakarna* by Mpu Ḍusun, which has been shown to contain elements from the Sanskrit *Kāraṇḍavyūhasūtra* (Nihom 1994: 136–139). From the chronicle *Deśavarṇana* we learn about the existence in East Java of two types of private Buddhist institutions, namely the *kavinayan* and a (more prevalent) *kabajradharan* (80.1); the former implies that monastic rules were followed, while the latter is of a tantric type where celibacy was not enforced. The text (77.3) associates a locale named *buḍur* (Borobudur?) with the latter type of establishment (Sinclair 2013), and also informs us that Java was visited by foreign monks (*bhikṣu*) coming from mainland India, such as a certain Śrī Buddhāditya from Kāñcī, who made an eulogy of the king “in countless verses” (93.1).³² While Buddhism declined and eventually disappeared after the fall of Majapahit, it seems that small communities were still extant in the sixteenth century: the Buddhist Siddha Buddhaguptanātha (Tāranātha’s guru), travelling from the Subcontinent to Java at that time, allegedly found the followers of the ‘Śravaka Sendhapa’ there,³³ and then proceeded to a small island in the middle of a lake, called *Vanadvīpa* (‘Forest Island’, perhaps in Sumatra?), where he saw the cave of Padmavajra (*mTsho skyes rdo rje*) and a two-armed image of Hevajra installed in a square-shaped temple, and heard about the existence of many tantric scriptures (Templeman 2009: 264). The

³²Cf. *Deśavarṇana* 83.4: “And so constantly all kinds of people come from other countries in countless numbers – See: India, Cambodia, China, Annam, Champa, the Carnatic and so on, Gaur and Siam are their places of origin, sailing on ships with the merchants in numbers. Monks and priests in particular, when they come they are given food and are happy to stay” (trans. Robson 1995: 185).

³³According to Skilling (1987: 16) the ‘Sendha-pa’ Śrāvakas could possibly have been Sāmmaṭiyas (Hīnayānist), deriving from *saindhava* or ‘residents of Sindh’.

tantric legacy and Śaiva-Buddhist coalition of Siṃhasāri and Majapahit appears to have continued in Bali to the present day, where Balinese Buddhist ritualists cover a subsidiary role in certain Śaiva ceremonies, and have preserved Sanskrit scriptures that include fragments from several authoritative works of the Mahāyāna and Vajrayāna (Hooykaas 1973: 600–603).

SUMATRA

Sumatra hosted renowned centres of Buddhist activity and learning. Seventh-century Chinese monk Yijing praised the high level of Buddhist scholarship that he found on the island, where he stopped *en route* from Guangzhou to Nālandā, and from where he procured the shipment of numerous Buddhist texts (Takakusu 1896: xxxvi). Yijing reports that Śākyakīrti, one of the five most distinguished Buddhist teachers of his time, travelled far and large across the ‘Five Indias’ and finally settled in Śrīvijaya (Śrībhoja) (Takakusu 1896: 184). The continued existence of a high level of Buddhist scholarship and royal sponsorship of the religion is also suggested by the later figure of Shihu/*Dānapāla (施護, d. 1018), an exceptionally prolific monk-translator who in the late tenth century reached China with a good knowledge of the languages of Sanfochi/Śrīvijaya and Shepo/Java (Sen 2003: 384; Orzech 2011: 449–450). Skilling (1997: 188) notes that the composition, in the early eleventh century, of the *Durbodhāloka* by *Dharmakīrti from Suvarṇadvīpa (which he locates in Kedah) “presupposes the existence and study in Śrīvijaya of the abstruse Prajñāpāramitā and Abhisamayālaṃkāra literature; of a high level of scholarship; and of royal sponsorship”.

Sumatra has yielded a corpus of stone tablets and other inscriptions on metal foils and statues that are notable in that they cite early Mahāyāna Sanskrit texts, including the *Suvarṇabhāṣottamasūtra*, which is regarded as ‘proto-tantric’ by Huntington (1987), and the *Aparimitāyuhṣūtra* (Griffiths 2011b: 169, 2014a: 152–154). The Talang Tuo Old Malay inscription of AD 684 recovered near Palembang has also been interpreted as an early document of Mantranaya Buddhism (Woodward 2004; Kandahjaya 2016: 82). The epigraphic legacy, coupled with the account by Yijing on texts on yoga and incantations (*vidyā*, *dhāraṇī*) available in Śrīvijaya,³⁴ and the Sanskrit-Old Javanese manual(s) *San Hyañ Kamahāyānikan/San Hyañ Kamahāyānan Mantranaya*, would seem to cast new light on the genesis of Esoteric Buddhism across the Buddhist cosmopolis (Kandahjaya 2016).

The *Intan* and *Cirebon* shipwrecks, discovered beneath the sea lanes linking Sumatra to Java, have yielded precious data on tenth-century traffic of Buddhist

³⁴Compare *Mañjuśrīmūlakalpa* 53.832, stating that the ‘wrathful mantras’ (*krodhanās mantrāḥ*) are practiced in the southern region, and in the islands of thieves and barbarians in the middle of the ocean (*krodhanās tu tathā mantrāḥ sādhyatāṃ dakṣiṇāpathe / mlecchataskaradvīpeṣu ambhodher madhya eva vā*).

bronze paraphernalia (including *vajras*, spear-shaped sceptres, bells, statuettes, and inscribed foils) along with other commonly traded merchandises among regional entrepôts and the larger Indian Ocean and Chinese markets.³⁵ On the Sumatran mainland, most of the archaeological remains and scant epigraphic documents spread over disparate locales of the island – especially along the Batang Hari river (for instance, Muara Jambi and Muara Takus) – have yielded remains of Buddhist monuments and inscriptions mostly dating back to the tenth to thirteenth centuries.³⁶ The 21 gold plates with inscribed seed-syllables and names of deities found at Candi Gumpung in Sumatra follow an arrangement that most closely resembles that of the Trailokyavijayamahāmaṇḍala as described in the *Vajrasekharatantra*, thus suggesting that Trailokyavijaya must have been the central deity of the *maṇḍala* (Nihom 1998).

From the eleventh century onwards, Sumatra appears to have been an important seat of the Hevajra cult: witness the epigraphic evidence of mantra portions directly quoted from the *Hevajratantra* (Griffiths 2014c: 230),³⁷ as well as the fourteenth-century inscription of Saruaso II, issued by crown prince Anaṅgavarman, son of Ādityavarman, which mentions his “daily meditation on Hevajra”, or his “ever keeping in mind the Hevajra(tantra)” (*hevajranityāsmṛtiḥ*; see Hunter 2015: 324–327). It would thus seem that Ādityavarman was following the same ideology and ritual technology adopted earlier by Kublai Khan and Kṛtanagara, who equated themselves to the central deity of the *maṇḍalas* of Buddhist tantras such as the *Guhyasamāja* and the *Hevajra*. The wild, ferocious character of the Esoteric Buddhist (and tantric Śaiva) iconography that developed at the east Javanese courts of Kaḍiri-Siṅhasāri and Majapahit shares features with the Sumatran iconography, as attested in Biaro Bahal and Muara Takus, and in the Mahākāla statue of Padang Roco, attributed to the fourteenth-century Ādityavarman. As suggested by Bautze-Picron (2014: 107), images found at the Sumatran sites of Padang Lawas are part of a network that connects them to east Java, South Asia, Cambodia and Campā in the eleventh and thirteenth centuries; overall, the sites show a kind of Buddhism that belongs to the same phase of Vajrayāna as that which was present in the Khmer and Cham domains between the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, and in east Java and China in the thirteenth century.

The contribution of Śrīvijaya to Vajrayāna Buddhism in Tibet, which can also be seen through the handful of texts composed in Suvarṇadvīpa that were introduced into the Tibetan canon, is acknowledged by the Tibetan tradition from the eleventh century, and confirmed by modern scholarship (see Chattopadhyaya 1981: 93–94; Schoterman 2016 [1986]). Atīśa, a native of Bengal, is said to

³⁵See Hall 2010: 15–45; Miksic 2016: 259–260; Liebner 2014: 191–194.

³⁶See Woodward 2004; Reichle 2007; Griffiths 2014c; Miksic 2016; Kandahjaya 2016.

³⁷Significantly, this text mentions Suvarṇadvīpa as a place of pilgrimage (Schoterman 2016 [1986]: 115).

have transmitted the *Durbodhāloka* (a Sanskrit commentary on the *Abhisamayā-lankāra*) to Tibet. This was composed in Southeast Asia by Atiśa's teacher *Sauvarṇadvīpī-Dharmakīrti under King Cūḍāmaṇivarman, who may have founded a Buddhist temple in Nāgapattinam around AD 1019 (Skilling 1997, 2007).³⁸ This Dharmakīrti may have been the master who imparted to Atiśa the teachings of the *Kālacakratantra*, and has been identified by van der Kuijp (2003: 420, n. 6) as the author of the *Netravibhaṅga*, a commentary to the *Hevajratantra*. Both Atiśa and *Dharmakīrti were fervent devotees of Tārā, whose cult was widespread in insular Southeast Asia, and which may have been popularized in Tibet by Atiśa after his stay in Suvarṇadvīpa (Schoterman 2016 [1986]: 119). Wilkinson (1991: 236–239) presents evidence for a connection between the cult of Gaṇeśa in Tibet and *Dharmakīrti. The transmission of Buddhist ideas from Sumatra and/or Java to the Himalayan region has been suggested on the basis of artistic and architectural similarities between the Tabo monastery in Himachal Pradesh, which Atiśa visited in AD 1042, and Borobudur.³⁹ Recently, Sinclair (2016b: 164–166) has also presented a case that the eight-armed form of Amoghapāśa in the Thām Bahī monastery in Nepal (founded by Atiśa) was introduced from the Śrīvijayan domains.

THE MALAY PENINSULA

Given its strategic geographical location, the Malay Peninsula, which was included in the domains of the staunchly Buddhist Śaileन्द्रa-Śrīvijayan rulers from the seventh to the thirteenth century, acted as an important intersection in the traffic of merchants, monks, and pilgrims plying the maritime routes. The middle part of the Peninsula was dominated by the city-state of Panpan from approximately the fifth to the eighth century, and has yielded Buddhist remains consisting primarily of statues, tablets, and votive *stūpas*. The city-state of Laṅkasukha extended over the region of present-day Pattani on the east coast, and has yielded the same type of material evidence plus Buddhist brick sanctuaries. According to Jacq-Hergoualc'h (2002: 183), this legacy reflects the dominance of the *Mūlasarvāstivāda* school up to the end of the seventh century, and the concomitant rise of Mahāyāna Buddhist tantra from the seventh century onwards.

The earliest inscription associated with Buddhism in Southeast Asia, dated to the fifth century, has been found in Kedah. Having been commissioned by sea captain Buddhagupta from Raktamṛttikā (probably Raktamṛttikā Mahāvihāra in what is now Rajbadidanga in West Bengal, or another unknown location in

³⁸Schalk (2002: 542) suggests that this monument, usually referred to as a 'pagoda', stylistically resembles structures from eighth to tenth century Java and Sumatra, and speculates that it might have been completed by artisans sent by the Southeast Asian ruler.

³⁹See Wayman 1981: 140–142; Nihom 1994: 72, n. 192; Kimmeth 2012: 98–99.

mainland Southeast Asia), it highlights the link between Buddhism and trade in the peninsula prior to the establishment of monastic centres and the rise of institutional support in the Śrīvijayan period (Sen 2014c: 46–48). Another important testimony to the translocal nature of Buddhism in the area is the existence of many votive tablets found at multiple sites in the period from the sixth to the twelfth century. Two of them, recovered from sites in Kedah and tentatively dated to the seventh century, quote a passage from the Mahāyāna Sūtra *Sāgaramatiparipṛcchā*, whose Sanskrit original has survived through fragmentary quotations but has been integrally transmitted in Chinese and Tibetan translations (Lammerts and Griffiths 2015: 994). Several clay tablets recently found in the Khao Nui cave in Trang province bear an abbreviated inscription of the Four Truths of Buddhism in Sanskrit (Revire 2015: 301–303, figs. 26.4–26.6), while other specimens display a Mahāyāna/early Mantranaya iconography (including, for example, the Eight Bodhisattvas). The specimens inscribed in northeastern Indian scripts, as well as those displaying a twelve-armed Avalokiteśvara from the Perlis caves, could have belonged to pilgrims transiting from the Subcontinent (unlike the tablets recovered from difficult-to-reach caves, which rather suggest a local context of religious practice: see Jacq-Hergoualc’h 2002: 47).

Besides controlling the trade routes, the Śrīvijaya thalassocracy extended at its height over Sumatra, the Malay Peninsula, and Java, and was actively engaged in Buddhist diplomacy with India and China. In addition to the donation by Bālaputradeva at Nālandā, other gifts and diplomatic exchanges with South India and Sri Lanka are documented in inscriptions dating from the eleventh and twelfth centuries (Jacq-Hergoualc’h 2002: 274–275, 346–347, 400). Under Śailendra rule, the Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, and Java shared several elements of Sanskrit Buddhist. The early triad of *bodhisattvakulas* of the Kriyātantras that we find at Mendut is mentioned in the Chaya/Vieng Sa (‘Ligor A’) inscription of AD 775 as Kajakara (Padmapāṇi-Avalokiteśvara), Māranisūdhana (Śākyamuni), and Vajrin (Vajrapāṇi), where a brick temple was dedicated by the royal chaplain (*rājasthāvira*) Jayanta and his disciple Adhimukti at the instigation of a Śailendra king (Long 2014: 25–27). The exquisitely crafted late eighth-century bronze Avalokiteśvaras found in the Chaiya district of modern Thailand and in Bidor (Perak, Malaysia) show close similarities with the Avalokiteśvara found at Wonogiri in central Java (Fontein 1990: 210–211). These remains suggest a link between the Malay Peninsula and Java under the Śailendras, perhaps also via *Vajrabuddhi (Sharrock and Bunker 2016), Amoghavajra, *Prajña, and other monks.

Links between Nusantara and Nepal can be evinced from the AD 1015 Manuscript CUL Add. 1643 (f. 120r) of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*, which mentions a Lokanātha on Mount Valavatī in Kedah/Kaṭahadvīpa (Kim 2014: 49, 63, 65).⁴⁰ De Mallman (1951) and Soper and Chapin (1970) proposed

⁴⁰Another illuminated manuscript of the same text from Nepal, dating from AD 1071 and partly based on CUL Add. 1643, does not contain any reference to both Kedah and Śrīvijaya. This fact

that the so-called ‘art of Śrīvijaya’ was influential on the Avalokiteśvara images produced in Yunnan around the eleventh to thirteenth century. De Mallman (1951: 573–574) also noted a similarity between certain stylistic features of these statues that, while being absent from Pāla art, are shared by specimens found in places located along the maritime networks, including the western Deccan caves, South India, Sri Lanka, Java, Sumatra, the Malay Peninsula, Campā, and Japan. This state of affairs led her to conclude that these motifs were of South Indian origins, yet they were diffused through the intermediary of Śrīvijaya.⁴¹

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has led Schoterman (2016 [1986]: 115) to speculate that that polity might have lost its prominent position in the Buddhist world after the Cōla raids.

⁴¹In a similar fashion, Lee Yü-min (reported in Bryson 2017: 416, fn. 31) argues that the iconography of Acuoye Guanyin, having originated in the Pāla and Pallava domains, reached Dali through Java.

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